

Can the benefit of AI, with its environmental harm and its potential deterioration of online or otherwise content and discussion, outweigh its cons?

Posted by u/Happness7 • • 0 points • 8 comments

I'm new to this Subreddit, so I hope I'm sticking to the rules reasonable well here, but feel free to let me know if not!

"Is AI worth all the harm it causes?" It's a question that's glued itself to my mind since I first learned about ChatGPT and all its environmental effects.

To better explain, let's do a little hypothetical.

So, let's say there is a being who has the accumulation of all publicly available human knowledge, from the short Reddit comment here to the decade-long scientific research paper there—but who works to give the most satisfying possible answer, even if that answer—regardless if asked to do otherwise—is completely inaccurate and even experiences “hallucinations” when under prolonged questioning or conversation where they give unrelated or detached responses. On top of that, they don't even truly understand what you ask or the answer they give you; they just think what they spit out is what would be “satisfying”—further, with every word, sentence, and paragraph they speak, they burn water away from the earth and damage the environment.

What would you ask them, knowing that there is a chance what they tell you is inaccurate, that they can never truly understand anything, and every conversation with them adversely affects the world you live?

Would you ask them anything?

If you couldn't tell, this is about AI. From my point of view, the benefit, even when used non-exclusively for high-end research, for say, gene editing, can still outweigh the downsides, especially if a way can be found to make the technology have a lesser environmental impact.

Even still, is its harm on our society. Slop being churned out and civil discussion being turned into nothing but bot and bot interactions. Can it be said that AI, as it is, has had a

positive effect on our intelligence on a mass scale? Honestly, this is where I trip up. It can be used to enrich one's self, via using it to guide one's self rather than seeking immediate answers without ever trying to learn. But at the same time, is it really being used like this? I would say, from what I have seen, it hasn't been. Kids use it to cheat in school, adults use it as a way of escapism, everybody seems to clutch onto it in one way or another, if they use it, at least.

I would say I lean more optimistic on AI. I think it can end with having left the world better than it was when AI was first invented—but I look around and see nothing but downside after downside. It's heartbreaking.

Please, let me know if I have broken any rules, or if this would possibly be better in another Subreddit! In all honesty, I don't use Reddit often, so I don't really know how to find better fitting Subreddits...

Comments

u/Underhill42 • 1 points • 2025-10-23 16:46 UTC

What benefit? Fake dog pics and propaganda videos?

For anything in which being anchored in reality is important, modern AI is hot garbage. Despite appearances it doesn't actually understand anything it says, it's just a non-random noise generator stringing words, pixels, etc. together in a plausible-seeming manner.

Information content is generally negative - ask it to write you a paper or answer a question you're likely to get at least 30% being inaccurate, and another 30% being a complete fabrication with no basis in reality whatsoever.

About the only area where it's a net positive is identifying potential patterns in large data sets, which is handy in astronomy and some other scientific fields, and mass surveillance of course, but that's about it. And personally I'd put mass surveillance in the big honking negative pile.

u/Happness7 • 1 points • 2025-10-25 04:19 UTC

>What benefit? Fake dog pics and propaganda videos?

Well, I was mainly thinking about the chatbots, I honestly even forgot AI image videos and images existed when I made the post. But I agree. In the case of AI images and videos, I see no benefit.

>Despite appearances it doesn't actually understand anything it says, it's just a non-random noise generator stringing words, pixels, etc. together in a plausible-seeming manner.

Again, we agree. I *know* it doesn't understand. That does not deny its usefulness, though.

>ask it to write you a paper or answer a question

Here is where we differ. I do not use AI for writing papers, because writing is inherently artistic and creative activity, so no matter the context, if you care about what's being written, then you shouldn't ask AI to write it for you. Hell, I'd say, just don't use it for that at all.

It's as you said, AI is good for pattern recognition. Use it to spot grammar mistakes in writings you did yourself, or use it to try to identify weak points in your writing in place of a beta reader. Of course, don't take what it said as truth, but it can definitely help find possible mistakes or flaws.

>...and mass surveillance of course, but that's about it. And personally I'd put mass surveillance in the big honking negative pile.

Agreed, but, that's what regulations are for, no? So instead of completely denying something that *could* be good over things that can be solved. Wi-Fi when it was first invented was so bad people thought it was nothing more than a fad, but it was given a chance and was proven miraculous, so why not give AI that same chance?

u/Underhill42 • 1 points • 2025-10-25 15:30 UTC

I excluded chatbots specifically, because I fail to see how talking to a chronic liar is even remotely useful.

As for regulations on surveillance - that only works if the people in charge of creating regulations aren't the same ones eager to implement mass surveillance to make their positions more secure and abusable.

u/Xandurpein • 1 points • 2025-10-23 12:20 UTC

There are huge problems with AI currently, but they have less to do with the technology and more to do with the insane financing model fuelling it currently.

AI reasearch is as much driven by largely ignorant venture capitalists that are driven by FOMO to throw money at anything that says "AI" rather than insights into actual research or a real value proposition.

u/notgotapropername • 1 points • 2025-10-20 22:57 UTC

AI is a tool. That's it. If I smash my fingers with a hammer, it doesn't mean the hammer is a bad tool, it means I didn't make good use of the tool.

ChatGPT is basically a fairground hammer: it's impressive, maybe even fun for a while, it attracts crowds of people who wanna give it a go, but at the end of the day it's not a practically useful activity. That's not to say that a really big hammer can't be useful though, we just have to apply it to things other than smashing a big button at the fairground.

The power of an LLM doesn't lie in asking it mundane questions and taking everything it tells you as gospel. Instead, if you apply an LLM to a targeted task, finetune its system prompt, connect it up to a surrounding system and maybe some tools, it has the potential to massively increase your productivity and ability. All of a sudden you have the opportunity to automate/streamline things that were either extremely difficult or impossible to speed up.

And that's just considering the glorified-predictive-text that is LLMs. Never mind the vast range of AI that's out there other than generative AI.

When it comes to resource use: AI research/development was, for quite a long time, focused quite heavily on being resource-efficient. There was lots of research showing how models could perform really well with minimal training, small training sets, low power usage. The "drain lake superior for every training run" approach has only really been adopted in the last few years by the so-called hyperscalers.

What I'm saying is that we don't know that this is the way forward. Signs are actually pointing firmly to "no, you can't keep scaling like this", and not just for energy usage reasons. The hyperscalers have taken the lazy approach: brute force the problem. Brute force is almost never the best approach. It may well be that we will develop better architectures, more efficient training methods, etc.

I personally don't use any online AI, but I run local models on my own PC every day. They don't consume much more power than my PC would use anyway, and I use them in a targeted way, not just asking them stupid questions. I get a lot of value out of them every day, but it's because I'm using my hammer to build stuff, not just smashing things for the sake of it.

u/Esseratecades • 1 points • 2025-10-19 11:17 UTC

It would be if it were heavily regulated.

Using Generative AI to make memes or answer questions you could've googled it a massive waste of resources, and using it as a teacher or therapist is flat out irresponsible.

However there are fields where it is pushing science and technology forward and actually is a boon to society. But when you dig deeper those discoveries don't need these massive general purpose LLMs. A handful of machine learning models specifically tailored to the field usually would have accomplished the same thing, at a lower cost, with fewer distractions, in a way that is easier to explain.

So "AI" as a concept is good for society and a massive boon, but implementations such as Chat GPT, especially when marketed and sold to the general public, are bad overall.

u/billdietrich1 • 1 points • 2025-10-19 07:49 UTC

AI / LLM / ML could help us develop new medicines, new materials, new processes that give huge benefits.

As with any new tech, there will be disruptions and losses too.

AI / LLM / ML is just getting started; I expect it will improve in all dimensions: less power use, less hallucination, more capabilities, etc.

u/Pjoernrachzarck • 2 points • 2025-10-19 04:31 UTC

Chatbots and generating pictures on the internet are a tiny part of this tech, and the way they dominate the discourse is misleading and infuriating.

It's currently changing not only what kind of problems we can solve in all fields of research, predominantly in math, environmental science, biology, chemistry and physics, and how fast, but most importantly what kind of problems we can even conceive of. This tech might enable us to custom-make any molecule, machine, method, solution we can think of, and many that we can't even think of. It allows us to ask new questions. Historically, this has often if not always been the mark of a tech that brings with it unbelievable damage as well as unbelievable progress. Do the 'benefits' of cars,

radiocommunication, firearms, language, space travel etc. outweigh the 'cost'? At some scale, new tech defies that question. It certainly defies it in its infancy.

This isn't about webcomics, customer service, or deepfakes. This is a tech that fundamentally, radically changes how researchers can handle enormous amounts of data on the search for patterns. It might kill us or it might make us immortal or both or neither.

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-10-19 03:03 UTC

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u/herrigendjemand • 0 points • 2025-10-19 01:52 UTC

>Can the benefit of AI, with its environmental harm and its potential deterioration of online or otherwise content and discussion, outweigh its cons?

In theory, sure, but LLMs are being very over-leveraged in terms of being sold as solutions to problems they can't realistically solve consistently.

>

So, let's say there is a being who has the accumulation of all publicly available human knowledge,

LLMs are the accumulation of the *symbols* of a lot of publicly available human knowledge but they do not have access to the underlying knowledge those symbols represent.

>

Can it be said that AI, as it is, has had a positive effect on our intelligence on a mass scale?

I don't think it can be claimed with any solid support that AI has had a positive effect on our intelligence at large. While some people have absolutely learned skills and information, the amount of misinformation LLMs have spread, both unintentionally via hallucinations and intentionally as propaganda bot agents, far outweighs the benefits.

It think it's pretty clear that LLMs are a bubble but the underlying tech will definitely be useful in some more targeted, narrow applications but it's being sold as general AI when it can't realistically achieve that, regardless of how many more data centers they build.

u/Happness7 • 1 points • 2025-10-25 04:30 UTC

I generally agree with you, but as I said in another comment, and u/notgotapropername has put much better than I could, AI, and LLMs like ChatGPT are a tool at the end of the day. With proper regulations and countermeasures, most of the negatives you have put forth would be largely eliminated. However, whether those regulations will come about in any meaningful length of time from now, seems pretty unlikely as is, though.

u/billdietrich1 • 0 points • 2025-10-19 07:51 UTC

> It think it's pretty clear that LLMs are a bubble

No, I think OpenAI and its financing are the bubble. LLMs are coming along just fine. They're improving.

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-10-19 01:36 UTC

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u/AutoModerator • 1 points • 2025-10-19 01:30 UTC

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